Liquidation

How did SSNCo's career come to an end?

All that can be traced is a bare, and sparse, report in the *Swadesamitran* that, on application to the district magistrate of Tirunelveli for liquidation of the company, a court order was issued on 4 July 1911 to formally close down the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company Ltd., Tuticorin.[59] The Court appointed one K.N. Sankara Iyer as the official liquidator.[60] Nothing is known of who initiated the process: the shareholders, creditors or vendors?

Who was managing the company's affairs at this inauspicious juncture is not known. The misery and ignominy that the shutting down of the idealist venture would have caused can scarcely be imagined. Success has many fathers, failure is an orphan. There were no Casabiancas on the burning deck. No names are mentioned at this point. Even S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar, P.V. Ganapathia Pillai and B.K. Ramaier who ran around like headless chicken in the dying months were missing. 'It gives great sorrow to know of the premature death of this company which had to face numerous hurdles and difficulties and had only recently shown signs of revival' was all that *Swadesamitran*, which had valiantly championed the company's cause through thick and thin, would say on the occasion.[61]

Apart from the brief report of *Swadesamitran*, the press had little to say. It must have hurt their pride to report on the collapse of the company in which so many had invested more than just money. Their honour and (national) pride had taken a beating.

I have been unable to trace any news of the liquidation process as it unfolded. How much was salvaged and how the proceeds were distributed are not known. Could the official liquidator even recompense an anna for a rupee?

Before the end of the year, even as the liquidation process was on, on 2 December, Pandithurai Thevar, the most generous benefactor of SSNCo died. He was only forty-four. The silence of his biographer notwithstanding, the collapse of the company likely contributed to his premature death.[62]